Living the Lord's Prayer

The Wise Men

Some time ago, I happened upon a television interview with billionaires Bill Gates and Warren Buffet.

It was the second part of a brief series in which the two billionaires accompanied one another to the universities they had each attended years earlier. Buffet went with Gates to Harvard, and Gates returned the favor by accompanying Buffet to the University of Nebraska.

The format of the program consisted of Gates and Buffet sitting on a stage surrounded by current undergraduate and graduate students, as well as professors and senior administrators. The most interesting part of the program came when members of the audience

posed questions to the financial titans. As one might expect, some asked "how to" questions, such as, "How did you make so much money and can you give me a tip or two to help me be as successful as you are?"

The most intriguing questions though, came from students who dug a bit deeper, probing for clues to what really makes these men tick. They inquired of them, "What do you most value? What do you think about in your private moments? What are you most passionate about? What is your definition of success? What principles guide your life?"

As the students were asking the questions, the camera periodically panned the audience. They were transfixed, captivated by these two men, the quintessential modern success stories, whose fame and fortune is envied by many throughout the world. As they both answered with candor and good humor, the students seemed to hang on their every word, hoping to find a pearl or two that would help them achieve the enormous success these two men now enjoy.

Watching the interchange between the students and their two guests was entertaining and educational. What impressed me most was how teachable, how thirsty, how docile, how wide-eyed, and how eager the students were

to receive whatever wisdom they could get from them. These men possess what most people seem to want: massive personal and financial success. To put it another way, it seemed as though the students were saying: "You've got what we want; we want to be like you; how do we get there?"

The Secret to Our Success

When the program ended, I began to think about the teaching Jesus left us about Himself in His word. The first thing that came to mind was the Lord's Prayer, the *Our Father*. Immediately, I was struck by what it revealed about Jesus' fundamental orientation to life. In that prayer, He has given us the kind of in-depth insight and "insider tips" that many people today desperately seek to acquire from today's biggest success stories. We all desire to be successful and to have our lives count for something. We believe that if we can just find out the real secrets behind others' success, we'll eventually get there ourselves.

In the Lord's Prayer, Jesus, who is history's most powerful, brilliant, loving, attractive, fulfilled and successful person, has given us access to the movements of His own heart, to the things He cared most about, to the truths that He lived and died for. There is no more valuable wisdom for true success than what He has left us.

Jesus is the definition of success. His ideas, values, priorities, and way of living did not end

with His death. His view of "what really counts" in life has been completely vindicated in His resurrection and ascension into the glory of heaven. He gave us His prayer, the Lord's Prayer, so that we can live the way He lived and eventually share in His eternal glory. Jesus is deeply concerned about our success, but it is not a success in this world only. Instead, it is one that will be defined in an existence beyond death, in an eternal life of unimaginable joy and fulfillment.

We all need wisdom to help us reach our potential in whatever walk of life we have chosen. Gaining insight from those who have achieved success is smart. Yet what others can give us, though valuable, is limited. What Jesus has freely given to us is of infinite value, and in the end, it will define whether we succeed or fail in life. What success is there in life if all our striving and accomplishments cannot take us beyond the grave?

A great deal can be learned from Warren Buffet, Bill Gates, and others like them, about reaching our dreams in this life, but only Jesus can—with absolute certainty—give us the wisdom we need to live a truly successful human life. Only with and in Jesus will our words and deeds, what we have accomplished in this life, live beyond the grave and echo into eternity.

My purpose in writing this short booklet is to inspire in you a passion and a hunger to gain the wisdom Jesus has given for your success. May His priorities become your priorities; may His vision and goals, the habits of His heart, become the ultimate guide for your own life.

"Lord, Teach us to Pray" (Luke 11:1)

The Gospels record many instances of Jesus spending time alone in prayer. The apostles saw firsthand that prayer, conversation with God, was the key to understanding Jesus' whole life and mission. It's what made Him tick, it fueled Jesus' ministry; it gave Him vision, clarity of purpose, identity and strength. The apostles knew that prayer was the place where the heart of Jesus was revealed. They wanted to go there, to touch His heart, to think, feel, and be moved by the same realities that moved Jesus at His deepest level.

Their simple request, "Lord, teach us to pray," yielded a goldmine of insight and wisdom into the heart of Jesus. Jesus taught them the fundamental principles—the foundational priorities—that guided His entire life. He revealed His mind to them, the habits of His heart, and the secret of His success.

The Father: Our Ultimate Goal

In teaching His apostles how to pray, Jesus was teaching them how to live. For Him, His

prayer was His life. What He prayed about each day was what He most cared about. His prayer reveals His priorities.

The first two words of prayer He taught the apostles summarized everything He wanted them to know: *Our Father*. As the saying goes, Jesus "began with the end in view." The Father is the goal of Jesus' life. From the start, Jesus is revealing to the apostles the unchangeable truth that human life is defined in relationship to God, Who is our Father. He determines the meaning of life. His plan alone can define what a successful human life looks like. Successful living begins with becoming *God-directed*. Without this basic, fundamental orientation in life, real success is literally impossible.

Here Jesus reveals something that far too many "successful" people fail to see today: ultimate and lasting success comes not from the pursuit of power, money, or the acquisition of material things, but in pursuing *a person*. Jesus knows that His apostles, and every one of us, will have dreams and set goals in the hope of making a successful contribution to society, and so it should be. But what He most wants us to see is that it is essential to always put "first things first." It's not complicated: if you want to become all you were meant to be, *put God first*!

Sometimes when I am meditating on the Lord's Prayer, I imagine Jesus saying to me, "The Father is the secret to My success, the motivation for My whole existence. He is My vision, My horizon, My passion. Living for Him is what human life is all about. If you miss this, you completely misunderstand Me, and everything I desire to give you."

He told his disciples: "My food is to do the will of him who sent me, and to accomplish his work." (John 3:34) Jesus' gaze is set on the Father. He came to make it possible for us to do the same. To each disciple, He gives the same piece of wisdom: it all begins with the Father.

For many of us, this first insight from Jesus will require conversion, a change in how we think, dream, and live. When we plan our day, when we set our priorities, when we think of our short-term and long-term goals, and when we face obstacles in our life, all of this must be seen through the optic of our relationship with the Father, with His purposes and plans for our life. Learning to hear His voice in prayer and following His lead is the first step to successful living.

Seven Habits of Jesus' Prayer

In the Lord's Prayer, Jesus has revealed the content and orientation of His own prayer. *The Catechism of the Catholic Church* speaks of the seven

petitions Jesus gave to the apostles as the core of a disciple's prayer. These petitions, or what I refer to here as habits, show us what filled Jesus' mind and heart. They encompass what Jesus thought about, what occupied His deepest reflection, and they reveal the concerns of His heart.

I'm always struck by how different Jesus' prayer is from my own. Too often, my prayer begins with me, and is often stuck on secondary things. I'm easily preoccupied by what I think I need or what I want to achieve. Jesus' starting point is different.

Hallowed be Thy Name

Jesus' first concern is the honor of the Father. His first goal in life, His mission, and His deepest desire is to see that the Father's name is respected, known, honored, and revered through Him. His passion is to see that all of humanity comes to know God as He is—holy, pure, awesome, beautiful, good, glorious, and completely trustworthy. He wants to see the name of the Father hallowed, that is, recognized and made holy.

Jesus is not only telling us something about the Father here, but He is answering one of the most fundamental questions of human life: why are we here? He is teaching us to pray that God's purpose for us would be revealed above all else. We were made for His honor and glory. We honor Him by the way we live.

This simple habit reveals the kind of radical reorientation that is needed within our own hearts, at the deepest level of our desires. Most of us seek our own glory. We desire the honor of men more than the honor of God. We are more concerned that *our* name be recognized. In fact, we often live in the fear that it won't be.

Jesus is free of the fears that preoccupy and dominate the human heart. The fear of failure, of not being recognized, and of not succeeding in the eyes of men, is of no concern to Him. He does not live in the minds of men; He lives in the mind of God. He's free because He knows the recognition of men is fleeting, futile, and of no real lasting value. We've got it all wrong; we frantically pursue the favor of men, often at the cost of forgetting God, because we actually believe it will bring us success and happiness.

Imagine beginning each day with the burning desire in your heart to see the name of God honored in all you do that day. Can you envision it replacing the anxious concern you have for your own welfare and recognition? Can you imagine it becoming a real passion? Jesus wants to retool our interior life; we need a new internal calculus so we can truly come to value what He values.

That new calculation includes "losing" oneself. This is what Jesus means when He tells

His disciples: "Whoever would save his life will lose it; and whoever loses his life for my sake, he will save it." (Lk 9:24) Jesus knows our hearts and minds need to change. He also knows that if we pray each day, with genuine sincerity for the name of the Father to be hallowed in our lives, it will eventually happen. Our hearts will change. If we want what He wants, He will give it to us. The question is, "What do you really want?"

Thy Kingdom Come

Here we can see that Jesus not only lives with "the end in view," but He keeps the "big picture" at the forefront of His mind. He knows that life on earth is fundamentally a battle between the kingdom of God and the kingdom of the devil. What is at stake is a battle for individual lives, for the hearts and minds of men, women, and children.

In this part of His prayer, Jesus reveals His desire to see the reign of God welcomed into our hearts. He began His ministry with the following declaration: "The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe the gospel." (Mark 1:15) He came bearing this message, calling all who heard it to change their lives. He proclaims that "the kingdom of God is at hand," because it has literally come in the person of Jesus Himself.

He has come to reveal the authority of the Father and to bring all of humanity into conscious surrender to His purpose and plan for their lives.

This prayer is meant to lead us into seeing our world in Jesus' terms. The concept of kingdoms in conflict, the world as a spiritual battlefield, and the existence of the devil can seem outdated, backwards, harsh, and almost delusional to the secular mind that dominates our culture. But here it is, Jesus' heartfelt prayer, and the One who knows the truth about reality is telling us that we ought to think about this every day of our lives. Jesus shed His light into this dark world so we can actually see the unfolding drama of human history around us.

Jesus' apostles eventually began to see reality on His terms. St. John tells us, "The reason the Son of God appeared was to destroy the works of the devil." (1 Jn 3:8) St. Peter warned, "Be sober, be watchful. Your adversary the devil prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour. Resist him, firm in your faith, knowing that the same experience of suffering is required of your brotherhood throughout the world." (1 Pt 3:8–9) St. Paul constantly reminded the brethren who they were and what Jesus had done for them: "He has delivered us from the dominion of darkness and transferred us to the kingdom of his beloved Son, in whom we have redemption, the forgiveness of sins." (Col 1:13–14)

That transfer of kingdoms has happened through the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ. Through His death, "he disarmed the principalities and powers and made a public example of them, triumphing over them . . . ." (Col 2:15)

It is that act of love that broke all the powers of darkness and established the reign of God forever: "The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of his Christ, and he shall reign forever and ever." (Rev 11:15) This is the core of who Jesus is: He is a King. In fact, He is *the* King of *the one kingdom* that will last forever. His passion and purpose is to bring all creation—every person—into that kingdom.

The prayer for the coming of the kingdom provides an orientation and a habit of thinking that is guided by Jesus' own priorities. It points the way for us to enter into Jesus' world, into reality itself, into the unfolding plan of God. The prayer is a personal pledge of our whole lives to the King. Through it, we give Him permission to reorient our priorities, to allow His mission to take precedence over everything else in our lives. Through it, we accept the authority of Jesus over our lives and take our place in the mission of the kingdom.

Jesus Himself said, "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me." (Mt 28:18)

That authority has been given to Him by the Father. He now reigns, using that authority to subdue the enemies of the Father: "Then comes the end, when he delivers the kingdom of God the Father after destroying every rule and authority and power. For he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet. The last enemy to be destroyed is death." (1 Cor 15:24–25)

In the end there will be one thing: *the Kingdom of God*. The Kingdom is God Himself, and all those who belong to Him. To the mind of Christ, there is nothing more urgent and pressing than the full establishment of the Kingdom of God in every human heart. Through this prayer, Jesus is leading us and training us to understand that to live in the Kingdom is to place His plans, purposes, and priorities first in our lives: "And he died for all, that those who live might live no longer for themselves but for him who for their sake died and was raised." (2 Cor 5:15)

Jesus said, "Fear not, little flock, for it is your Father's good pleasure to give you the kingdom." (Lk 12:32) The Kingdom is a gift that comes from the heart of a loving Father. It is *given to all those who welcome it* from the depths of their hearts. Jesus wants to teach us to welcome this gift.

Thy Will Be Done

What is God's will? *The Catechism of the Catholic Church* begins its reflection on this petition by quoting the Bible: "Our Father 'desires all men to be saved and come to the knowledge of the truth.'" (CCC 2822) God most desires our salvation. This is the will of God. Jesus came to fulfill the will of God. He freely set aside His safety, security, comfort, pleasure, preferences, position, and plans in order to submit His life to the will of the Father.

Can you hear Jesus' message to us in this petition? What *I want* is not of first importance. What really matters in life, what will lead to genuine fulfillment and happiness, is to want what *God wants*. Jesus could not have been more explicit about this fundamental truth in His own life:

> For I have come down from heaven, not to do my own will, but the will of him who sent me... (John 6:38)
>
> My food is to do the will of him who sent me and to accomplish his work. (John 4:34)
>
> I seek not my own will but the will of him who sent me. (John 5:30)
>
> My Father, if it be possible, let this cup pass from me; nevertheless, not as I will, but as thou wilt. (Mt 26:39)

Here Jesus is laying the axe to the root of the tree for all of us. He is exposing our hearts by the light of His own life. We live in a world that exalts those who live for themselves. We reward those who exercise power over others for their own ends. We idolize radical autonomy, and insist on our own right to define the meaning of reality, to determine what is true, and to name good and evil. Happy hedonism is the dominant ideal of our popular culture. And if we look closely, into our own hearts, we find an affinity, a subtle attraction to these ideals, and a resistance to a full, conscious embrace of the will of God in our lives.

It has been said that there are two kinds of people in the world, those who say, "Thy will be done," and those who say, "My will be done." In this prayer, Jesus is seeking to produce a radical reorientation within our hearts. He lovingly exposes our resistance to God and shows us how to put that resistance to death. He is telling us: "Pray with me. Pray like me. Ask and it will be given to you. You will become like Me."

This petition or habit reveals just how far our own priorities are from the Father's. He wants, above all things, to see every person He has created "saved and come to the knowledge of the truth." It is so important to Him that He sent His beloved Son to die for it. How much

do we really desire this? The world works overtime to pressure us to not think about it, to be slightly embarrassed about this archaic notion that some people actually need to be "saved." Even within the Church, there is at times a subtle pressure to put this fundamental goal on the back burner or to push it off the table completely.

When I was in school, I had a brief debate with a Catholic theologian that illustrates my point. While defending a thesis I had written in which I was speaking about the importance of preaching the Gospel in order to seek the "salvation of souls," the professor looked at me and said: "Who could you possibly be talking about? Don't you know that the Church recognizes that people are already saved?"

What would be the point of praying and working with Jesus for the salvation of souls, that God's "will be done," if everyone is already saved?

The recent popes have all heralded the same message in an attempt to lead the entire Church to embrace the fundamental truth that "the task of evangelizing all people constitutes the essential mission of the Church," that it is the "grace and vocation proper to the Church, her deepest identity. She exists in order to evangelize."[1]

Pope John Paul II wrote with eloquence and a sense of urgency on behalf of the bishops of the Americas, to every Catholic in America, to see mission and the work of evangelization as a defining aspect of what it means to follow Jesus: "To follow Jesus involves living as he lived, accepting his mission, adopting his way of thinking, embracing his destiny and his project, which is the plan of the Father: it involves inviting everyone to communion with the Trinity," and that, "The *burning desire* to invite others to encounter the One whom we have encountered is the start of the evangelizing mission to which *the whole Church is called.*"[2]

Why does the Church "exist to evangelize?" Why is it a defining aspect of being a follower of Jesus? Why should it become a "burning desire" within "the whole Church"? Because it is the burning desire and a consuming concern in the heart of Jesus: "Being with him (Jesus) includes the missionary dynamic by its very nature, since *Jesus' whole being is mission.*"[3]

Jesus lives to please His Father, and He knows, in the depths of His heart, that the Father "desires all men to be saved and come to the knowledge of the truth." (1Timothy 2:4)

This petition is meant to lead us to this point, to sharing in the very passion and heart of Jesus and the Father for the salvation of all.

Many of us don't share this passion; it simply is not a priority. That is why Jesus wants us to pray this prayer every day from our hearts. He wants to reshape our minds and hearts, to line up our priorities with those of our Father in heaven. Why? So we can become what we were meant to be; so we can share in the mission and ultimately share in the victory of the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

Give Us This Day Our Daily Bread

In this petition, Jesus leads us to seek to share in His utter and complete dependence upon the Father. He wants us to trust the Father, to stand on the conviction that the Father is for us and that He is utterly trustworthy. We are not alone in this world. God is not a fickle, distant, harsh, capricious taskmaster Who is nearly impossible to please. He is a loving Father Who is committed to us without limit.

Each day, Jesus looked to God for His daily provision. He knew He could count on the Father to look after Him and to give Him everything He needed. His ultimate provision did not lie in the hands of other men, or in the circumstances of His life; nor was He subject to fate, or even His own ability to provide for Himself.

This is not an unrealistic intention, or some kind of concession to idleness and pas-

sivity. This is a value and habit of life given to us by the most focused, driven, passionate, competent, powerful, and intelligent man Who ever lived.

It is a disposition of life that allows us to understand our actual condition before God. We are limited, dependent creatures. We know instinctively that this is true, but the realization of it leads us to a life dominated by fear and anxiety.

Knowing the truth about the Father's love, Jesus literally commands all those who want to follow Him to live by this truth: "Therefore, I tell you, do not be anxious about your life, what you shall eat or what you shall drink, nor about your body, what you shall put on." (Mt 6:25) This seems, on the face of it, to be a completely unrealistic expectation. Not to be anxious about anything! It seems as though our natural state is to be anxious about everything! That's because we don't know the deep and real love of the Father and how much we can truly depend upon it. In our own minds, we are left with nothing but our own resources to rely upon.

We're afraid for our lives. We're anxious about tomorrow, fearing it will not end well for us, and that our resources are insufficient. This fear creates an anxiety and underlying sense

of panic that we spend a great deal of time frantically seeking to eliminate. We scramble for security, hoping to find it somewhere other than in God. Money seems to promise the relief we need; it exercises a kind of power over us because it appears to be the antidote to our problem. We put faith in money, believing that with money, "all things are possible," so we pursue it relentlessly and it can become an idol. In the end, it is like a medication that provides nothing more than temporary relief; it cannot cure our problem.

Jesus too is unrelenting: "And which of you being anxious can add one cubit to your life span?" Remember, "Your heavenly Father knows what you need. But seek first the kingdom and his righteousness, and all these things shall be yours as well." (Mt 6:27, 32)

Real surrender and dependence upon the ultimate provision of a loving Father, Who is all powerful, and Who is utterly faithful to His promises, provides the foundation for the security of mind and heart we need in order to live the life to which God calls us. Jesus can say, no matter what He is facing, "not my will, but yours be done," because He knows where His security rests. That knowledge produces freedom and confidence in God, Who is the determiner of His destiny, not man. Nothing can separate Him from that destiny. No matter

how terrible or difficult the trials of life can be, not matter how much circumstances seem to contradict this truth, Jesus knows He is safe in the hands of His Father.

"God indeed is my savior; I am confidant and unafraid. My strength and my courage is the Lord, and he has been my savior." (Isaiah 12:2)

That is the confidence this petition is meant to produce in our lives as well. If we pray this prayer from our hearts, accepting the truth Jesus has revealed, leaning on it, we too will be able to say, like Jesus and the apostles:

"Hence we can confidently say, 'The Lord is my helper, I will not be afraid; what can man do to me?" (Heb 13:6)

Forgive Us Our Trespasses as We Forgive Those Who Trespass Against Us

This is a disturbing petition. Jesus is leading us to place ourselves in a very difficult spot. That is, to ask the Father to forgive our sins based upon the condition that we forgive those who have sinned against us. It is a conditional proposition. Simply put, if we don't forgive, we won't be forgiven. That is a scary thing to pray.

It's scary because we don't like to forgive those who have harmed us. Forgiveness means to release those who hurt us from the debt we

believe they owe us. Our instinctive response to being hurt or sinned against by another, if you are like me, is to want to withhold mercy. We don't want to let them off the hook; we want them to pay for what they've done.

Why does Jesus insist upon this kind of internal disposition and habit of life? Because that is what God is like—full of forgiveness. Jesus made forgiveness possible through His death on the cross. From the cross, He prayed for each of us: "Father, forgive them, for they don't know what they are doing." (Lk 23:34) The Father heard that prayer, and all those who welcome Jesus receive complete forgiveness for all the sins they have committed.

The apostles understood what they had received and what was at stake in Jesus' command to forgive: "Be kind to one another, tenderhearted, forgiving one another, as God has forgiven you." (Eph 4:32) St. Paul knew he had been forgiven much. And he knew well that we are all prodigals who stand in desperate need of forgiveness. We've all sinned against God and our neighbor; and God, in His infinite mercy, has forgiven us.

It does no good arguing your case with Jesus: "Yes, but do You know what this person has done to me?" Yes, He does. And He knows what your sins and mine have done to Him.

Unforgiveness blocks the flow of God's mercy. It hardens the heart; it binds, it cripples, and it makes it impossible for the love of God to penetrate and heal the human heart. It stifles the Spirit; it is the stubborn rejection of love and of God's triumph through mercy.

Through this petition, Jesus is leading us to cooperate with God's work of breaking down our stubborn resistance to His will. He's expanding our contracted hearts, making room in us for love. In these words, we give God permission not only to treat us as we treat others, but to make us capable of receiving His Spirit, of living with a new heart: "And hope does not disappoint us, because God's love has been poured into our hearts through the Holy Spirit who has been given to us." (Rom 5:5)

Lead Us Not Into Temptation

This petition is a call to vigilance. Through it, Jesus wants to teach us to be alert, clear-minded, and ready for action—to be awake to the unavoidable combat against sin and the tactics of the devil. Jesus knows the reality and power of temptation, because He himself was tempted: "For we have not a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but one who in every respect has been tempted as we are, yet without sin." (Heb 4:15)

Because Jesus was tempted in "every respect," He knows clearly what we are up against. He knows our weakness and our affection for sin, but He also knows how to lead us out of sin and into a life where "sin will have no dominion over you." (Rom 6:14)

The fact that Jesus commands us to pray against temptation on a daily basis is an indication of how important our battle against sin really is. Sin kills. It's the one thing that can destroy us—forever. Sin, no matter how good it looks, or how thrilling it feels, always damages our lives. At its core, sin is a refusal of God, a conscious rejection of His plan and purpose for our lives.

Because sin has the potential to destroy, Jesus demands a total commitment against sin from all those who desire to follow Him. His closest followers, the apostles, knew this and were unequivocal in their teaching to those who wanted to follow Jesus: "In your struggle against sin you have yet to resist to the point of shedding your blood." (Heb 12:4) There is no limit to what we are called to in our personal battle against sin.

This petition trains us for battle. It instills in us a readiness for action and leads us to think and pray preemptively in our struggle against sin. Jesus wants this to become a habit in our lives; He wants our minds to be trained and alert.

There is no casual approach to sin. Jesus is totally intolerant of sin.

We like to play with sin, to keep it within reach, and we cultivate affection for our favorite sins in order to keep them alive and near at hand. We're often trapped by our own weakness, what St. Peter called, "the passions of our former ignorance," and from "futile ways" of thinking and living. (1 Pt 1:14, 18) The ignorance and futility of mind is expressed in the fact that we think we can manage sin, that we can have some of it, when we think we need it, and suffer little or no consequence. Or, we convince ourselves we cannot live without our favorite sins and that God understands that we all need a little escape now and then. What more stark expression of futile thinking could there possibly be than the belief that sin—the one thing that has the power to destroy my life forever—is somehow good for me?

Without a deep resolve within our own hearts, and a radical dependence on the Lord and His wisdom and power in this area, it is easy to become ensnared in habit patterns of sin that leave us despairing of ever getting free. How often have you felt discouraged, convinced that you'll never change?

That's exactly what the devil wants you to believe— that you are a lost cause, too weak and pathetic to ever live differently. He wants to lead

you into slavery and self-condemnation, to steal whatever hope and light might be within you. And that is precisely why Jesus is leading us to develop within ourselves a no-compromise commitment to do battle against sin on a daily basis.

Each one of us can win this battle, if we lean into Jesus and live by the power of His Spirit. He has defeated sin: "The Lord knows how to rescue the godly from temptation." (2 Pt 2:9) And despite what you may think, no matter how powerful the temptation you face may feel, or how deeply ingrained the habit of sin may be, Jesus has a way out for you: "No temptation has overtaken you that is not common to man. God is faithful, and he will not let you be tempted beyond your strength, but with temptation will also provide the way of escape, that you may be able to endure." (1 Cor 10:13)

You and I can gain victory over sin in our lives because "God is faithful." In Christ, He has already acted on our behalf. He has won the victory over sin that we need: "The death he died he died to sin, once for all, but the life he lives he lives to God. So you also must consider yourselves dead to sin and alive to God in Christ Jesus." (Rom 6:10-11)

In this petition, Jesus is teaching us how to gain victory over sin. He's training us to look to God each day, to lean into Him, to tap into His power, to literally share in His victory over sin

here and now! Because of what Jesus has done, we don't have to be slaves to sin:

> Let not sin therefore reign in your mortal bodies, to make you obey their passions . . . for sin will have no dominion over you . . . you have been set free from sin . . . so now yield your members to righteousness for your sanctification! (Rom 6:12, 14, 18, 19)

It's time for you to take your stand against sin. It begins with a decision from the heart to accept Jesus' attitude and disposition toward sin. He wants us to pray daily from the heart, that we "not be led into temptation." We know "God cannot be tempted with evil and that he himself tempts no one." (James 1:13) But we appeal to Him, knowing He is the source of our strength, believing in His power to rescue us from the power of every temptation.

If you haven't taken this petition to heart and you want to make a change, tell someone. Tell a brother or sister in the Lord. Open up your life. Stop hiding. Tell the truth about sin in your life. Find a priest, go to confession, and remember that if you "humble yourself under the mighty hand of God, in due time he will exalt you." (1 Pt 5:6) You can take that to the bank!

Deliver Us From Evil

Finally, Jesus brings us face-to-face with our mortal enemy. The devil is real. Our battle is with

him: "We are not contending against flesh and blood, but against the principalities, against the powers, against the world rulers of this present darkness, against the spiritual hosts of wickedness in the heavenly places." (Eph 6:12) He is pursuing you: "The devil prowls around like a roaring lion seeking someone to devour." (1 Pt 5:8) He has a plan for your life: to enslave you and ultimately to destroy you.

Jesus knows His enemy. He knows his tactics and strategies against us. He also knows how to defeat him: "He disarmed the principalities and powers and made a public example of them, triumphing over them in him [on the cross]." (Col 2:15) This petition is intended to help us gain victory over the devil in our own lives.

This habit of mind—to look to God for help to defeat the plans and strategies of the devil—seems bizarre to the modern mind. The idea of the devil as a personal, malevolent being who is set against us and our future, is considered archaic, backward, and unenlightened. Most people today simply deny his existence, while others do just the opposite—they exaggerate his role in daily life and find him lurking around every corner.

Jesus does neither. In this petition, He wants to continue to make us battle-ready and to develop within us the instinct to look to God as the

source of our strength: "Finally, be strong in the Lord and in the strength of his might. Put on the whole armor of God, that you may be able to stand against the wiles of the devil." (Eph 6:10) The victory belongs to the Lord. Here He teaches us to stand in that victory on a daily basis through a conscious appeal for His help, to learn to lean on Him, and to trust Him for deliverance: "'God is my refuge and fortress; my God, in whom I trust.' For he will deliver you from the snare of the fowler and from the deadly pestilence; he will cover you with his pinions, and under his wings you will find refuge; his faithfulness is your shield and buckler." (Ps 91:2–4)

Living the Lord's Prayer

Jesus knows from firsthand experience that deliverance comes from the Lord. The whole of life is a spiritual combat. There is only one way to win this battle, and that is to walk with and in Jesus. He has shown us the way. He's lived it. He's confronted all the obstacles we will ever face in this world, and He has triumphed over them.

In the Lord's Prayer, Jesus has revealed the secrets to His success. If we live this prayer, if we take it to heart, finding within it Jesus' formula for success, we too will share in His victory. The life He now lives in eternal glory, we are destined to share. His passion is to see each one of us enter into that glory. Living the Lord's Prayer is our pathway to glory.

Notes

1. Pope Paul VI, Evangelii Nuntiandi, 14.

2. Pope John Paul II, Ecclesia in America, 68.

3. Pope Benedict XVI, Jesus of Nazareth, p. 172.